



OFF-SIDE

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WHERE THE AIR IS THIN AND CRICKET OPINIONS THICK

Cricket conversations in India never end. The game changes every few years, opinions shift every few overs, but the **obsession remains permanent.**

The everyday Indian sports expert exists everywhere: in office cafeterias, tea stalls, apartment lifts and WhatsApp groups. Sometimes, he is also driving you through the mountains to Dharamsala.

Few stadiums can match the Himachal Pradesh Cricket Association Stadium, where the snow-capped Dhauladhar range rises so beautifully behind the ground that it is often hard to focus on the cricket.

In a country where watching sport in May usually means enduring heat and humidity, Dharamsala feels almost unreal: a place where you can sit through a game in peak summer without breaking a sweat and simply enjoy the cricket. The stadium, elegantly carved into the mountainside, is slowly emerging as one of India's premier cricket venues, shaped significantly by the efforts of former Union Minister Anurag Thakur and his brother, Arun Dhumal, who have steadily improved facilities and infrastructure in the region. The State, too, is beginning to establish itself as a meaningful breeding ground for talent, particularly in women's cricket.

Our charioteer for the journey was Ajay, who proudly claimed to have played age-group cricket for Himachal Pradesh, including once hitting the State's 2021-22 Vijay Hazare Trophy-winning captain Rishi Dhawan for six at an even more picturesque ground in Baijnath, near Bir Billing, India's paragliding capital.

Barely 10 minutes out of Chandigarh, with the plains still radiating heat, the conversation had already drifted towards cricket.

Like every great Indian sports expert, Ajay's opinions

carried conviction. To him, Suryakumar Yadav was merely a "*lapetu*", someone who keeps hoicking deliveries across the leg side rather than playing "real cricket shots". But his tone softened when he spoke of Sachin Tendulkar. Tendulkar, for him, remains untouchable. Still the god.

Modern T20 cricket, though, leaves him unconvinced. The boundaries are too short, the bats too powerful, and bowlers reduced to "traffic policemen standing helplessly while everything flies past them."

A score update on the radio. A mention of Virat Kohli. Perhaps a complaint about team selection. That is usually all it takes in India for a conversation to turn into a cricket debate.

"Sir, Rohit should have retired after the World Cup."

"No, no, Kohli still has two years."

"Sooryavanshi? Good talent, but footwork needs improvement."

Ajay, too, was at the stadium for the Mumbai Indians-Punjab Kings game, ostensibly to catch a glimpse of Rohit Sharma, "who still makes batting look impossibly easy." **Rohit disappointed, but Tilak Varma ended up doing exactly what Ajay had spent hours criticising on the drive up to Dharamsala: clearing the ropes repeatedly to drag Mumbai Indians to victory and silence the Punjabi voices around him.**

On the way back, Ajay was full of praise for Tilak's innings. His earlier complaints about modern T20 batting had seemingly disappeared somewhere in the mountains.

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